

plainsong

Medieval church music also known as plainchant; consists of a unison, unaccompanied vocal line in free rhythm, like speech, with no regular bar lengths.

pizzicato

A style of playing stringed instruments that are usually played with a bow, by plucking the strings with the fingers.

polyphony

Literally “many sounds,” this refers to a style of writing in which all parts are independent and of equal importance, and therefore implies **contrapuntal** music. Forms that typify this style include the **fugue** and **motet**.

prelude

A short piece of music generally intended as the introduction to a longer composition, although sometimes used for stand-alone pieces.

programmatic, program music

Any music written to describe a nonmusical theme, such as an event, landscape, or literary work.

recitative

A style of singing in **opera** and **oratorio** closely related